

30Minutes Expert

Fortify that Screen Saver

We know that Windows 98 isn't exactly Fort Knox when it comes to security. But even today, it continues to power the majority of desktop computers. However, it does offer a crude one-stop defence mechanism in the form of the Screen Saver password. With a few simple tweaks, it can be used quite effectively to cover up some of Windows 98's inherent security flaws.



Setting the screen saver password

Right-click on an empty area of the Desktop and select Properties from the drop down menu. Now choose the Screen Saver tab and select a screen saver of your choice. Click the 'Password protected' tick box and then click on 'Change...'. This will open up a dialog box where you will be prompted to enter a new password. Remember to follow the usual safety guidelines while picking a screen saver password: don't use simple keywords such as your name or initials. This is important as the Screen Saver password allows for an infinite number of retries and an easy password has a higher probability of being 'guessed' out. You will see a 'The password has been successfully changed.' message after you've typed in your new password. Click OK to finish.

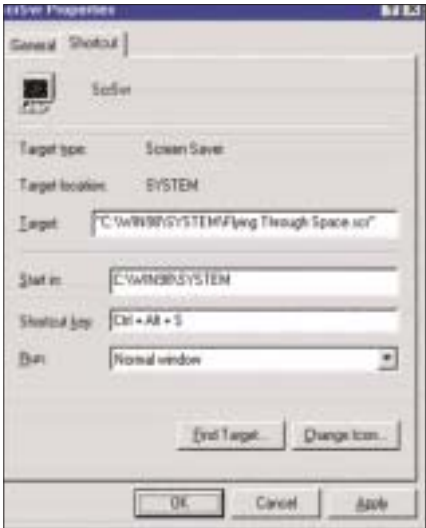


Activating the screen saver on demand

A screen saver only starts up if the computer is idle for a predefined period of time. But you can also invoke the screen

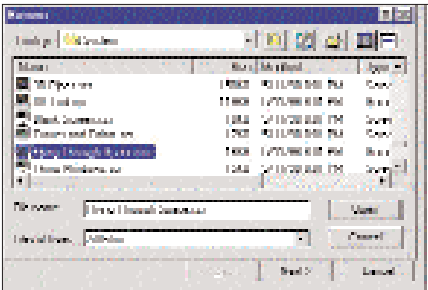
saver on demand by creating a shortcut for it and then assigning it a hotkey.

Right-click on an empty area of the Desktop and select New and then Shortcut. This will open the Create Shortcut dialog box. Click on Browse and navigate to the System subfolder under the folder where Windows is installed (typically C:\Windows). Now click on the 'Files of type' drop down list box and select All Files. Double-click on your screen saver, click on Next to assign a name for the shortcut, type something simple like ScrSvr and click on Finish. A shortcut will be placed on the Desktop. You can now invoke the screen saver by double-clicking on the ScrSvr icon.



Assign a Shortcut key to your screen saver

To make it even easier to invoke the screen saver, assign it a hotkey. Right-click on the ScrSvr icon on the Desktop and select Properties. Now click on the 'Shortcut key' field under the Shortcut tab. Any shortcut key combination will include the [Ctrl] and [Alt] keys by default; choose any key, say [S], as your shortcut key. Finally, click OK. You can now launch the screen saver by simply pressing [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [S].



Create a shortcut to your screen saver



Screen saver as your Windows lock

In Windows 98, the default guest login offers full access to all system resources. Thus, it only takes a simple reboot to override the security measures provided by the screen saver password. A registry hack can remedy this and in turn provide some semblance of a login control system (actually it will only prevent unauthorised access, but in a single user environment, that's just as effective).

Click on **Start > Run** and type **regedit**. Remember to back up the Registry



Auto start the screen saver with Windows startup

files (the system.dat and user.dat files in your Windows folder) to avoid accidents. Now navigate to HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run.

Click on the Edit menu and select New then String Value'. Give this string value any name such as 'SSLock'. Right-click the newly created String Value and choose Modify. This will open up the Edit String dialog box. Enter the path to the Screen Saver shortcut file that you created earlier in the 'Value data' field. Finally close the Registry Editor.

Now Windows will automatically load the screen saver whenever it starts up. And as we've enabled the Screen Saver Password feature, you will always be prompted for a password upon boot-up. This ensures that only someone who knows your Screen Saver password will be able to use the machine.

Your screen saver is now configured to provide on-demand security at the press of a shortcut key and will also prevent unauthorised use of the machine upon boot-up. Simple, yet highly effective. ■